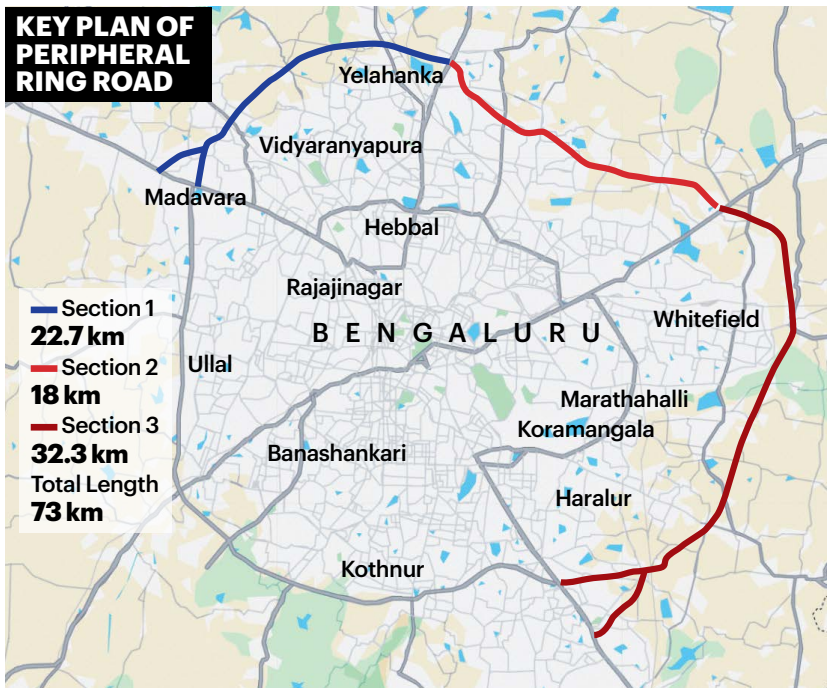
KARNATAKA

Peripheral Vision Comes Full Circle

On the anvil for 20 years, a grand project to decongest Bengaluru finally moves—but cannot bypass local ire



The 19.8-km first phase links Tumkur Road with Bellary Road. By April 1, 83 per cent of the land required for it—480 out of 576 acres—had been acquired. "By May end, we will be issuing work orders for it," says BBC chairman L.K. Atheeq. Farmers, he adds, are persuaded by the new package: alternative residential or commercial plots, transferable development rights (TDR) and compensatory floor area ratio (FAR) in lieu of cash.

Mavallipura B. Srinivas, president of the farmers' body PRR Raitha Hagu Niveshanadarara Sangha, disagrees. "Farmers who have agreed are typically those who lose smaller plots, with the value of their remaining land increasing with road access.

Takeaways

- **Renewed push by deputy CM DKS sees 73-km Peripheral Ring Road project chug to life**
- **An idea for 20 years ago, it aims for a new 'outer ring road'**
- **But only if irate farmers agree**

Those who lose more have not agreed," he claims. He rejects the package, insisting on invoking the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013. "We have no objection to the road. We, too, have a social concern," he says. "We will give up the land if compensated as per the 2013 Act." That will be tied to market value plus a solatium matching the value of assets on the land.

Srinivas says guidance values in the 65 villages along the arc have not been hiked since 2016, artificially depressing rates. Many farmers have petitioned the high court to quash the entire land acquisition, arguing the project has lapsed. "For 20 years, we've been unable to get a loan, sell land for emergencies, or carry out family partitions," says Reddy, whose village falls in the third phase. Meanwhile, new apartment projects have sprung up nearby, spiking land prices; Reddy cites transactions for as much as Rs 30 crore an acre. The BBC's offer for his village? Rs 5.55 crore. "We are not ready," he says, bluntly.

Krishna Ramesh, from Kachamaranahalli village next door, echoes that veto. His five-acre plot is marked for acquisition, but he points out ruefully that the cash being offered doesn't add up to even 20 per cent of the sum paid out recently under the 2013 Act to acquire land for a railway project nearby.

TEDIOUS ARC

TDRs accord better rates, but Ramesh says landowners are sceptical about being able to sell these certificates since a new FAR policy already allows property owners to pay a premium for additional FAR. "If you own above one acre and lose only 20 per cent, TDR or FAR may be beneficial," says Ramesh, who has his hopes pinned on the court.

The BBC says the rates approved in October—from Rs 2.34 crore to Rs 15.60 crore per acre, depending on locality—are an attempt to bridge the gap with market rates, being twice the guidance value in urban areas and thrice that of rural areas. Overall, the BBC is looking to acquire 1,810 acres from 3,586 farmers for the 73-km road, with another 600 acres needed for new clover-leaf intersections on its radar. Progress may be as tortured as it is on an average Bengaluru street. ■